

Individual Entrepreneur Events and Reflection #1

Case Study of Stripe

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Course: MAIE5535

Date: 13 March 2026

Due to technical issues accessing the Prof E platform, I have not been able to complete the required dialogue component. I have contacted the instructor via Canvas Inbox and follow-up email regarding this matter but have not yet received access to the system. As the deadline has passed, I am submitting the reflection portion first to ensure timely documentation of my work. The Prof E dialogue component will be completed and uploaded once access is restored.

WHAT

For this entrepreneurial learning event, I conducted a case study on Stripe. I read Stripe's official website, background articles about its founding, and several discussions about why developers preferred Stripe in its early years. What stood out to me most was that Stripe did not begin by trying to change the entire financial industry. Instead, it focused on one specific and frustrating problem: making online payment integration much easier for developers and digital businesses.

At this stage of my entrepreneurial learning journey, I still see myself more as an observer than a builder. I am interested in startups, technology, and innovation, but I usually prefer clear structures, predictable paths, and enough preparation before taking action. Because of that, I often spend more time analyzing than trying. A concrete challenge I am facing is whether my habit of "preparing more" is actually helping me, or whether it has become a way to avoid uncertainty and possible failure.

From studying Stripe, I gained one important insight: entrepreneurship does not always begin with a big vision or a fully developed plan. It can start from identifying one narrow but meaningful problem and solving it well for a specific group of users. This idea felt very relevant to me because I often imagine entrepreneurship as something too large, risky, and far beyond my current ability.

This experience also relates to my group project. In our discussions, we sometimes spend too much time thinking about features and what a complete solution should look like. Stripe's example reminded me that it may be more useful to first define the core user problem clearly before expanding the idea.

SO WHAT

This experience matters to me because it changed the way I interpret my hesitation. Before this case study, I usually thought my uncertainty about entrepreneurship came mainly from lack of experience, knowledge, or confidence. After looking more closely at Stripe, I realized that part of the issue may be my strong preference for certainty. I feel more comfortable when expectations are clear and when I know how I will be evaluated. Entrepreneurship feels difficult to me not only because it is challenging, but because it requires acting without complete information.

Stripe's story helped me see entrepreneurship in a less dramatic way. I used to associate entrepreneurship with bold personalities, constant risk-taking, and large-scale ambition. However, Stripe showed me another path: careful observation, technical understanding, and solving a practical problem step by step. This matters because it feels closer to how I naturally think and work.

It also helped me reinterpret my current situation. Instead of asking whether I am "ready" to become an entrepreneur, I can ask whether I am willing to begin with a small, concrete step. That shift feels important. It reduces some of the pressure I place on myself and makes entrepreneurship seem more like a learning process than a final identity.

For my group project, this reflection also reminded me that a clearer problem definition may be more valuable than adding more functions too early. That is a practical lesson I can apply immediately.

NOW WHAT

After this reflection, I do not plan to make a dramatic change. Instead, I want to take two small and practical steps.

First, in my group project, I will encourage my team to focus more clearly on the single most important user problem we are trying to solve. I want to pay more attention to problem definition instead of jumping too quickly into features. I hope this will make our project more coherent and easier to explain.

Second, I will do one personal experiment. Within the next two weeks, I will identify one everyday inconvenience in student life, study workflow, or digital tools, and I will write a short problem statement that explains who experiences the problem, what the

frustration is, and why it matters. I am choosing this step because I want to practice moving from observation to action, even on a small scale.

I want to do this because I have noticed that my biggest obstacle is not a lack of interest, but a lack of movement. I often wait until I feel more prepared. What I expect to achieve is not a startup idea right away, but a better habit of acting before everything feels certain.

I will know this reflection has been useful if two things happen: first, if my contribution to the group project becomes more focused on clarifying the user problem; second, if I complete my own problem statement and feel more comfortable taking a small step without needing a complete plan first.